

LITERATURE AND CINEMATOGRAPHY: A PRACTICE OF SCREENING THE NOVEL VIA LITERARY DRAMATIZATION AND THE CULTURE OF ADAPTATION

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Abstract

In this paper, an attempt was made to review what literature (both oral and written) entails, and the different forms in which it manifests in our societies. There was also some diligent efforts to reexamine the genres and subgenres of literature, literary criticism, and evaluation of approaches to the study of literature itself. However, the link or relationship between cinematography and prose fiction, especially the novel sub genre was established. At the end, we are able to establish that there exists a symbiotic relationship between the literary text, "novel" and their cinema" where it is adapted or translated into a new medium – the "film" for visual purposes and entertainment. We reevaluated two Nigerian novels – Things Fall Apart by Chinua Achebe and The Tragedy of Adata by Michael Nwaesei, which fall under this lot. These texts have been adapted and produced as films and are ready for visual recreation and pleasure. These tragic novels are better appreciated in their new forms.

Introduction

Literature (either oral or written mediums) is one humanistic discipline that has remained multilayered or has interdisciplinary links with other areas or fields of study either in the Arts. Social Sciences, or even the Sciences. Over time, literary scholars have traversed over the waters and mountains of different areas of human endeavours. Through the powers of the literary imagination and creativity, literary experts have got the prerequisite knowledge or expertise to discuss almost every area of human existence. In this paper, what we refer to as literature or literary masterpiece shall include all forms of oral literary traditions as practiced in societies that have no written traditions (mainly in Africa) and other written forms of the literary culture. The oral forms include fables, tales, songs, tongue twisters, myths, legends etc, which can conveniently be subcategorized under the major tripartite divisions of literature as drama, poetry and prose. All the divisions or subdivisions of literature (oral or written) are subsumed here. Each genre has its own characteristics or peculiar features which stands out in the comity of all others.

Drama, which is believed to be one of the oldest forms of the literary tradition, is traceable to the reenactment of ritualistic performances. In the modern times, drama is closely associated with stage performances or crafts where the actions and inactions of characters are mimicked or imitated to the pleasurable entertainment of the audience in a theatre or cinema hall. It translates words into action. There are other subgenres of the dramatic forms such as tragedy, comedy, tragic-comedy, romantic comedy etc. However, dramatic forms are written in "scenes and acts" where the thoughts or ideas of characters are relayed to the audience through their lines or turns

and turn-taking in conversations or dialogues.

Poetry is regarded as one of the oldest forms of the great literary culture or tradition. It is reputed to be the most difficult to be studied or understood by wary or scary students who do not have the patience to interpret meanings from the words in which poets hide their intended meanings. The poetic form uses more condensed language, figurative, imaginative or expressive language that is short, witty but loaded with meanings and subject to some valid varied interpretations in line with the thoughts or ideologies that underpin a particular poem. There are also some subgenres of the poetic medium such as elegy, odes, sonnets, lullaby, epic, dirge etc. It is very pertinent to observe here that poems are written in verses or stanzas. They pay much attention to the harmonious or otherwise, phonological arrangements of words in any order during presentations. However, connotation rhythm, rhymes, and tone are very dominant features of poetry or poems.

The Prose genre deals with either short or long narrative fiction or nonfiction which tells stories about human life, experience of that of a community or society at large. Under this canopy, there is a short story, novella (longer than a short story but shorter than a novel) and the novel – a long narrative that can be either a fiction or nonfiction but dwells in treating or presenting human experience in the society.

Aesthetic Use of Language

Among the genres of Literature listed in the foregoing, there is a common thread that binds them together. That is the special way in which they use Language to transmit human experience. Here, Language is the major vehicle through which literature is driven. It is the creative manner, expressive way, imaginative and condensed usage of language that makes any work or writing to be judged as either literature or not. The two levels of meaning of language come to mind here. The levels of denotation (ordinary meaning, literal meaning or the dictionary meaning) and the connotation (extra-ordinary meaning, literary meaning, associative meaning or figurative meaning). It is at the domain of the latter that literature dwells or flourishes.

Furthermore, literature also has some tools or devices which help or assist its scholars to read or appreciate it more easily or without tension. They can also be technically or professionally referred to as Elements of Literature. These include plot, setting, themes, characters, characterization, point of view, diction, persona, tone, mood and poetic devices. For the sake of time and space, I may expatiate on them much later, but for now, they are worthy of mention as I have just done. If the need arises much later, I shall beam my search light on them for more explanations.

Literary Dramatization

Literary critics or evaluators have over the years, adopted so many approaches to the study of literature or literary culture, tradition or forms. In this work, we liken the approaches to literary criticism as keys which are used to unlock the doors of the mansion – “Literature”, before one can gain entrance into the main building. Going by this building metaphor, it would be expected that it will be practically impossible to have only one key to access this mansion. By this implication, there are so many keys to be used. Some of them include Formalism, Eco-

criticism, New historicism, Feminism, Marxism. Sociological Approach, Psycho-analytical Approach etc. They are called literary theories. Each of them has peculiar ways in which they approach the critique of any literary production.

Nevertheless, it is at the background of literary theorization that I shall hinge my arguments on and link it up with literary dramatization and screening of the novel. It is pertinent to note here, also, that we shall be dwelling more on the domains of literary dramatization which is western oriented and influenced, but will be domesticated by the use of African Texts (Nigerian mainly) – the classic *Things Fall Apart* by Chinua Achebe and a new prose fiction – *The Tragedy of Adata* by Michael I. Nwaesei.

The concept of literary dramatization as depicted in this research, is the translation of the words on paper (novels or other texts) into action (performances such as in theatres or cinemas). Therefore, there is a synergy between what is being said in black and white and the attempts being made to adapt same into performing acts where humans can visualize them and feel the real impacts of such creative production. As noted earlier, there have been so many approaches to the study or evaluation of different literary forms, but cinematography, literary dramatization and novel screening are very new when put in comparative paradigm with all others. As to be expected in any scholarly enterprise, there would be a sharp division of those who agree or are opposed to a particular idea or thoughts. In this paper, we shall examine the postulations or views of some literary scholars and their perceptions on this newest concept.

This paper takes its theme from the relationship between literature and the contemporary means of production and distribution collectively termed 'the media', in particular, film and television. The intention is to evaluate the mutual opportunities and restrictions in this relationship. In the grammar of our culture, there seems to be an accepted opinion that print is superior in terms of cultural production of film, radio or television, that to read a book is somehow a higher cultural activity than seeing a play on television or seeing a film. By the same token, a novel is a superior work of art to film or television. The longer perspective reveals that traditionally, there, always, is a greater respect paid to the previous mode of literary production – Poetry was superior to drama, poetic drama was superior to the novel, and film attained classic status initially over television.

Adaptation

However, the key term here is “adaptation” from literature to cinema and our focal point is on the prose fiction – the novel. Adaptation is the translation of a novel so that it fits a new destination, a new target or a new audience. Film adaptation was referred to by Belon Vidal Villason “as a memory – object of its source.” Here in literature, this supposed role of adaptation makes critics eager to continually discuss the degree to which a film is faithful to the literary work. Whereas in literature, the reader fills in the blanks himself, imagining the space and the character, but cinema provides the audience with ready-made characters, in flesh and blood, and a definite outline of space. Adaptations may make the understanding of an already read novel easier. The characters are alive and tangible as well as the context (Peace pAmala, 44).

The strategy to literary criticism or dramatization has its own pitfalls too as studies have shown

over the years. It has been revealed that adaptations do not make young people more interested in reading books. The opposite is more frequent. Young people are interested to watch adaptations of books already read. Watching an adaptation of novels or classic does not necessarily make people read more. Still, adaptations may inhibit the imagination because everything is shown on the screen, there is no place left for imagination. Besides, there may be a bias in the narrative and facts may be altered.

Movies are adaptations of a piece of work that, in a matter of fact, does not have to be that faithful to the original version of it. Some critics insist on the fidelity criteria, and by insisting they underline the fact that the film-maker has a different perception or reading of what the critic saw by himself. It is irrelevant to talk about fidelity since each reader perceives his readings from his own point of view. Two readers of the same novel may not see or capture the same things or feelings. Two viewers may have totally opposite opinions of a classic adaptation ranking from irrelevant to outstanding. The adaptation issue has been repeatedly evoked by several authors and critics. Some writer attempted to categorize adaptation in order to attenuate the eagerness towards the fidelity criteria. Brian McFarlane discussed this issue and exposed the categorization efforts made by different authors. Geoffred Wagner suggested three classes. The first is labeled “transportation” where the original literary work is given without substantial interference. The second category is labeled “commentary” where the original text is intentionally or involuntarily altered in some respect. Wagner evokes here different intentions rather than infidelity or violation. Then, the third category is labeled “analogy” which represents a fairly departure for the sake of making another work of art.

Adaptation of the Novel

Critics when assessing an adaptation work should be able to identify first the category to which the work belongs. This attempt to define classes tries to tell that fidelity criteria is over venerated and should not be considered as a critical criterion. A faithful adaptation may definitely be interesting and attractive. This does not make an original work based on a source novel but has reinterpreted and even transformed it; less valuable. Alfred Hitchcock has considered the novels on which he based his films as raw material that has to be reworked. Films and literature tell stories. Making a film is making a continuous unit that tells an evolving story, that is also what a novel does. When novels use only words counting on the reader's mental picturing, cinema gives it all in a plate with an individual interpretation of the novel. It is a transfer from one medium to another, a visual translation. Movies supply great deal of visual information and facts. They make you see visually through the eye, and literature make you see mentally through the mind. If the idea of seeing is present in both media, then the root difference lies between the mental and visual perception which expression of art evokes. However, they undeniably have in common that propensity for narrative. Literature evolved from representational novels used to recount and describe events towards unfolding events dramatically, similarly to what cinema does. They both have the aptitude to verify their characters and to depict parallel actions. It is possible that a film maker longing to be faithful to the original novel or classic, spends tremendous efforts in reproducing the time period, which may lead to exaggerating some aspects. The direction may become obsessed with the idea of realism so that he falls in his narrow vision of time and space, which he reflects through his experience and interpretation of facts.

Going by our experience here, in this literary climes, Achebe's classic; *Things Fall Apart* (a novel reputed to have been translated into over 50 languages) centres around the protagonist; Okonkwo, who symbolizes African nationalism and anti-colonialism. Okonkwo represents everything African and resents western-centrism. It is detestation of the aliens which propels him to commit suicide when it becomes almost impossible for him to stop the influx of western influences in African cultural values. All this can be better appreciated when one sits in the comfort zone of his parlour to watch the movie *Things Fall Apart*, which is a cinematomic adaptation of the novel *Things Fall Apart* by Achebe. The major events in the novel such as the wrestling contest, new yam festival, masquerade displays and his reception from his maternal home, are all pictorially presented for the easy grasp or interpretation of an average reader or audience.

In Nwaesei's novel: *The Tragedy of Adata*, we are confronted with a maiden struggling to free herself from the chains or burdens of a high-handed patriarchal oligarchy in form of some odious cultural practices or tradition that hinders her freedom and that of her husband, Udo. For them, the palace is a symbol of repression, oppression and servitude. The traditional ruling class and the spiritual headship – Chief priesthood act as aids or abettors to this heinous crime against “womanity”. Adata is punished beyond every known rational reasoning for defiling the god of Tanamaka River and as such, she could not be pardoned. She is humiliated during her virginity test, lost her pride, and above all, she loses her life and that of her unborn baby. In fact, the cultural practice of Anioma are so unfair and callous to the women folk as represented by Adata. In solidarity, her husband, Udo, breaks away from the shackles of tradition and embarks on an exile from home which signals the beginning of his freedom and that of the entire kingdom from the gods and traditions.

Conclusion

This paper has successfully established a relationship between literature and cinematography through the aid of adaptation and literary dramatization. However, the focus has been on the “novel” which is one of the sub genres of literature. Films and novels tell stories, making a film is making a continuous unit that recounts and describes unfolding events in an evolving story, that is also what a novel does. However, movies supply visual information, they make you see through the eye while novels make you see through the mind. If the idea of seeing is present in the booth, then the difference lies between the mental and visual perception which has been linked together with the use of cinematography through the aid of adaptation.

It is very important we underscore the point here that the novels *Things Fall Apart* by Achebe and *The Tragedy of Adata* by Nwaesei are better understood and appreciated when their adapted forms – into cinemas and films are studied cum viewed. This symbiotic relationship in literary dramatization between a text and its adapted form into cinemas or films is more efficient, educating and entertaining. Consequently, this new development should be encouraged and adopted in our various universities for effective learning and understanding.

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